



Manmohan with Obama and leaders of China, Brazil and South Africa at Copenhagen

scratchy. If the cornerstone of his foreign policy initiatives in his first term was the nuclear deal with the US, Manmohan had hoped that working towards a durable peace with Pakistan could be the enduring legacy of his second. Yet the haste with which he and his team went about it saw him lose plenty of political capital.

At the Sharm el-Sheikh summit with Gilani, without laying the groundwork for a policy shift, Manmohan inexplicably bent backwards by delinking action on terror with resumption of the composite dialogue with Pakistan. He then threw caution to the winds by indicating that India was willing to discuss Pakistan's charges of its interference in Balochistan stating, "We have nothing to hide on the subject".

Given that 26/11 was still fresh in the nation's

AT COPENHAGEN, MANMOHAN BROKE NEW GROUND ON CLIMATE CHANGE SIMILAR TO THAT OF THE N-DEAL.

Even as the Opposition screamed "sell-out", he encouraged Environment Minister Jairam Ramesh to chalk out a bold, forward-looking policy in consonance with China, Brazil and South Africa and thrash out a new accord with the US.

memory and all evidence pointed to the involvement of certain sections of the Pakistan Government, even the Congress party was hard put to back its prime minister and its silence spoke volumes. Manmohan then made a quick but studied retraction in Parliament, insisting that the composite dialogue would not move forward till Pakistan took convincing action against the perpetrators of 26/11. The damage had been done. India and Pakistan were back to square zero. Manmohan had squandered one of his best chances of making a differ-

ence in relations with Pakistan. Lalit Mansingh, a former foreign secretary, points out: "After that, CPA-II has been scared into caution and is wary of taking bold initiatives." That showed up in his summit with Obama, where despite their obvious rapport, the two leaders were not able to come up with a new big idea that would propel relations into a higher orbit or even iron out kinks in the nuclear deal.

On Sri Lanka, India was not able to persuade President Mahinda Rajapakse to make a grand gesture of reconciliation towards the Tamils after the

death of LTTE chief V. Prabhakaran. This despite India committing Rs 500 crore towards rebuilding war-torn Sri Lanka. In Nepal, the political situation has again deteriorated after the Maoist government led by Prachanda was pushed out and a seemingly moderate coalition, friendlier to India, had taken charge. Prachanda had thumbed his nose at India by tilting towards China. India-bashing is once again a favourite past time in Kathmandu. In Bangladesh, the emergence of Sheikh Hasina has seen a marked improvement in